

Word family: **age / ages / aged / ageing / aging / age-related**

Base word: age

Plural: ages

Past tense: aged

Past participle: aged

** -ing form:** ageing / aging

Related forms: aged, ageing / aging, age-related

Part of speech: noun (名詞) / verb (動詞) / adjective-related uses (相關形容詞)

Your sentence:

> “It may sound like a small thing now, but **at that age** it meant the world to me.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **age** means the **particular period of a person's life measured by how old they are**.

The speaker means that when he was still a young child, the incident felt much more important emotionally than it might seem now.

繁體中文： ** 某人在當時人生中所處的年齡階段，以已活了多少年來衡量 **

中文翻譯：

> “...but **at that age** it meant the world to me.”

「.....但在**當時那個年紀 / 年齡階段**，對我來說真的非常重要。」

Here:

at that age = 在當時那個年紀 / 人生階段

1. **age = how old someone/something is (年齡) — 年齡；歲數**

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Meaning: The number of years that a person, animal, object, etc. has existed.

Practice 1 — Original

> “At that **age**, it meant the world to me.”

「在當時那個**年紀**，那件事對我來說非常重要。」

Practice 2

> “Children of that **age** usually learn very quickly.”

「那個**年齡**的兒童通常學得很快。」

Practice 3

> “What **age** were you when you started school?”

「你幾**歲**開始上學？」

age = 某人或某物從出生、形成或出現至今所經過的時間，通常以年計算**

Common:

- * at the age of seven
- * children of the same age
- * what age...?
- * age difference

These belong to one core **how old** sense.

2. **age** = stage/period of life (人生階段) — 年齡階段；某個年紀**

Sometimes **age** focuses less on the exact number and more on the **life stage associated with that age**.

Practice 4

> “At her **age**, she values stability more than excitement.”

「到了她那個**年紀 / 人生階段**，她更重視穩定而不是刺激。」

Practice 5

> “Children at that **age** need plenty of encouragement.”

「處於那個**年齡階段**的兒童需要很多鼓勵。」

age = 某人在人生發展中所處的年齡階段，而不一定強調精確歲數**

This is very close to Meaning 1.

For database counting, I would **merge it with #1**, because both concern:

> **how old someone is / the life stage associated with that age**

The Golden Manual says contextual differences should be merged when one broader semantic concept naturally explains them.

3. **age = period in history (歷史時代) — 時代 ; 年代**

This is a genuinely different meaning.

Meaning: A particular period in history characterized by certain developments, technologies, beliefs, social conditions, etc.

Practice 6

> “We live in the digital **age**.”

「我們生活在數碼**時代**。」

Practice 7

> “The discovery changed life during the industrial **age**.”

「這項發現改變了工業**時代**的人類生活。」

age = 歷史上具有某些共同特徵、技術或社會狀況的一段時期

Common:

- * digital age
- * information age
- * industrial age
- * space age
- * modern age

This is clearly different from a person's biological age.

4. **age = very long period / era (漫長時期) — 漫長年代 ; 時期**

In some contexts, **age** means a very long period of time, often broader than an ordinary

historical period.

Practice 8

> “The cave remained hidden for **ages**.”

「那個洞穴隱藏了**很長很長的一段時間**。」

Practice 9

> “It feels like **ages** since we last met.”

「感覺我們上次見面已經是**很久以前**了。」

ages = 很長的一段時間；很久

This is especially common in the plural:

> **for ages**

I would treat this as a distinct conversational extension because the meaning is no longer a literal measured age or named historical era.

5. **age** = grow older (動詞) — 變老；老化

As a verb, **age** means to become older.

Practice 10

> “People **age** at different rates.”

「不同人的**老化 / 變老速度**不同。」

Practice 11

> “He seems to have **aged** considerably over the past few years.”

「過去幾年，他看起來**老了不少**。」

age = 隨時間過去而年紀增加，身體或外表逐漸呈現老化

This is the main verb meaning.

6. **age + material/product (物料 / 產品) — 老化 ; 陳化 ; 熟成**

Objects and substances can also **age**.

Practice 12

> “Wood changes colour as it **ages**.”

「木材隨着時間**老化**會改變顏色。」

Practice 13

> “The cheese is **aged** for several months before sale.”

「這種芝士在出售前會**熟成 / 陳化**數個月。」

age = 隨時間產生物理、化學或質感上的變化

Depending on context, Chinese may become:

* material → 老化

* wine/cheese → 陳年 / 熟成

For core counting, I would keep this separate from human ageing because the learner concept shifts from:

> **getting older biologically**

to:

> **material/product developing through time**

7. **age something (使老化 / 使顯老) — 使變老 ; 使顯老**

Age can also be transitive.

Practice 14

> “Stress can **age** a person quickly.”

「壓力可以令一個人很快**顯老 / 衰老**。」

Practice 15

> “The harsh sunlight had **aged** the paint.”

「強烈陽光令油漆**老化**了。」

age something/someone = 令某人或某物更快呈現老化或歲月痕跡

This is related to the verb senses above rather than a wholly separate core meaning.

Related form: **aged**

Aged has several useful uses.

aged = of a particular age (.....歲的)

Practice 16

> “The programme is for children **aged** seven to ten.”

「這個課程適合**七至十歲**的兒童。」

aged + number/range = 年齡為某個數字 / 範圍的

aged = old / elderly (年老的)

Practice 17

> “The charity supports the **aged**.”

「這間慈善機構支援**長者 / 年老人士**。」

This use is more formal and can sound dated depending on context; **older people / elderly people** is often more natural in ordinary modern English.

aged = matured over time (陳年的 / 熟成的)

Practice 18

> “They served **aged** cheese.”

「他們供應**熟成芝士**。」

Practice 19

> “The restaurant offers **aged** beef.”

「這間餐廳供應**熟成牛肉**。」

****aged = 經過一段時間儲存或處理，使味道、質地或品質發展成熟的****

This belongs to the product-aging sense.

Related form: ****ageing / aging****

****Ageing / aging** means the process of becoming older or deteriorating with time.**

Practice 20

> “The country has an ****ageing population****.”

「這個國家有一個****人口老化****的問題。」

Practice 21

> “Scientists are studying the ****ageing**** process.”

「科學家正在研究****老化過程****。」

****ageing / aging = 隨時間增加而變老或逐漸老化的過程****

Spelling note

****British English:** ageing is especially common**

****American English:** aging is standard**

Both are accepted forms.

Fixed expression: ****come of age — 成年；成熟****

Practice 22

> “She ****came of age**** during a period of major social change.”

「她在社會重大轉變的時期**成年**。」

Practice 23

> “The technology has finally **come of age**.”

「這項科技終於**發展成熟**。」

come of age = 達到法律 / 社會上的成年階段；亦可比喻某項技術、產業或事物發展成熟

This is an important fixed expression rather than another core meaning of bare **age**.

Fixed expression: **of age / under age — 達法定年齡 / 未達法定年齡**

Practice 24

> “You must be **of age** to sign the agreement yourself.”

「你必須達到**法定年齡**才可以自行簽署協議。」

Practice 25

> “He was still **under age** at the time.”

「他當時仍然**未達法定年齡**。」

These are fixed age-status expressions.

Fixed expression: **for ages — 很久**

Practice 26

> “I haven’t seen him **for ages**.”

「我已經**很久**沒有見他了。」

Practice 27

> “We waited **for ages**.”

「我們等了**很久很久**。」

****for ages = 很長的一段時間；很久****

This belongs to Meaning 4.

Important distinction: ****age vs old****

****age****

is a noun/verb referring to how many years someone or something has existed or the process of getting older.

****old****

is an adjective describing someone or something as having existed for a long time or being of a certain age.

> “What is your age?”

= 你的年齡是多少？

> “How old are you?”

= 你幾歲？

In ordinary conversation, ****How old are you?**** is much more natural than ****What is your age?****

Important distinction: ****age vs era****

****age****

can mean a historical period characterized by a major feature:

> digital age

****era****

means a distinct period in history or development, often defined by events, leadership, or style.

> Victorian era

They overlap strongly, but ****age**** often foregrounds a broad characteristic of the period.

Important distinction: **age vs generation**

age

= how old someone is, or a historical period

generation

= people born and living around the same period, or one stage in a family line

> people of the same age

> people of the same generation

These are related but not identical.

Important distinction: **aged vs old**

aged seven

= 七歲

Not:

> **old seven**

But:

> seven years old

is correct.

aged cheese

= 經過熟成的芝士

Not simply:

> old cheese

because **old cheese** may just sound stale or old rather than deliberately matured.

Family-extension note

The practical modern family includes:

* **age**
* **ages**
* **aged**
* **ageing / aging**
* **age-related**

Useful expressions and compounds include:

* at the age of
* at that age
* digital age
* for ages
* ageing population
* age-related change
* come of age
* of age
* under age

The Golden Manual says useful compounds, grammatical patterns, and common modern domain uses should be included while closely related contexts remain merged under broader semantic concepts.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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age — how old someone/something is	某人或某物從出生、形成或出現至今所經過的時間，通常以年計算
age — life stage	某人在生命發展中所處的年齡階段；與一般「年齡」義高度相關
age — historical period	歷史上因共同技術、社會狀況或特徵而形成的一段時代
ages / for ages	很長的一段時間；很久
age — verb, person	隨時間過去而年紀增加、逐漸變老
age — material/product	某種物料、食品或產品隨時間發生老化、陳化或熟成
aged + age range	年齡為某個數字或範圍的
aged — matured product	經過一段時間儲存或處理，使味道、質地或品質發展成熟的
ageing / aging	隨時間增加而變老或老化的過程

For your original sentence

> “It may sound like a small thing now, but **at that age** it meant the world to me.”

The exact meaning is:

age = 當時所處的年齡 / 人生階段

More specifically:

at that age = 在當時那個年紀，亦即仍然是小孩子的階段

So:

> **at that age** it meant the world to me

= 在當時那個年紀，那件事對我來說真的非常重要

For your database, I would count **5 genuinely useful core meanings** for **age**:

1. **how old a person or thing is / stage of life**
2. **a historical era or period**
3. **ages — a very long time**
4. **verb — become older / make someone or something look older**
5. **verb — material or product matures/deteriorates over time**

I would merge exact age and life-stage uses under #1, merge transitive/intransitive human ageing under #4, and keep **come of age**, **of age**, **under age**, and **for ages** as fixed-expression extensions rather than inflate the core count.